

PRINTING SOLUTIONS

Printing solutions are a big part of computing and are so many branches of it. Firstly, there are the printers which are then further branched out to inkjet and laser printers. Then, there are the MFDs which can do pretty much everything – print, scan, copy, send faxes and so on.

The two categories relevant to Indian users were laser printers and inkjet MFDs. Cost of ink and the running costs in general were also a big factor. The Zero 1 awards for printing solutions were to be given to the categories best suited for home and also SoHo users. Inkjet MFDs allow users to take photo quality prints while on a budget and at the same time be able to use its other functions such as copying and faxing. With prices so low already, it's possible to get MFDs with good quality and performance for affordable rates – somewhat like what inkjet printers used to be. Laser printers were the other big category where speed and low running costs were essential. We tested loads of such devices and this was our conclusion at the end of the year.

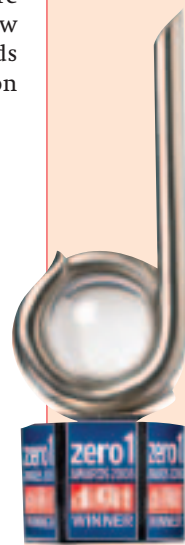
Inkjet MFDs

BEST PERFORMER

Canon MP 610

The Canon MP 610 was one of the most promising MFDs during the test this year. It was one of the costlier MFDs at the beginning of the year and is now just Rs 2,000 cheaper at the end of the year. The MP 610 has all the features including the inbuilt screen, memory card reader that allows you to print photos directly on the MFD. The most impressive part about the MP 610 was its speed. The scanning unit supported very high resolution scans but the quality wasn't the best as expected. The scanning quality suffered but the printing performance was astonishing. For the kind of performance that the Canon MP 610 exhibits, Digit awards it the Best Performer award for the Inkjet MFDs category. It is to this day the best performing MFD we've come across. Even if were to be used as a printer for the most, it still makes a very good purchase. It is our overall winner for Best Performer in the Printing Solutions category.

ance was astonishing. For the kind of performance that the Canon MP 610 exhibits, Digit awards it the Best Performer award for the Inkjet MFDs category. It is to this day the best performing MFD we've come across. Even if were to be used as a printer for the most, it still makes a very good purchase. It is our overall winner for Best Performer in the Printing Solutions category.



REIGNING CHAMPION

Canon MX 308

The Canon MP 610 was one of the fastest MFDs in the test. The Canon MX 308 on the other hand was one of the cheaper MFDs. It makes a very good choice for the *Best Buy* award. At Rs 6,595, it has a lot of the features of the MP 610. The performance wasn't so bad either in the tests. It led all the MFDs of its category in all of the tests. A newer version of the MX 308 – the MX 318 was also present for the test. The performance of the MX 318 matched that of the MX 308. The reason it didn't win was because MX 318 came with an ADF feature but was priced a lot more than the MX 308. The *Best Buy* award for the test was awarded to the Canon MX 308 for this very reason. The only complaint that we had was its weight. For an entry level MFD that would most likely be used by a home user, it was too bulky.



Laser Printers

REIGNING CHAMPION

HP P1505

The HP P1505 was a printer for the category of small work group category. The 1505 was clearly the fastest of all the printers in its category. Fast prints speeds didn't result in poor quality. The prints in the tests were crisp and accurate. The HP P1505 is then a winner for not just its brute force performance but also for consistent quality prints. If you think that the memory onboard the HP P1505 isn't sufficient, then more can be added. How many more printers in its price bracket can you do that with? For its speed and reliable quality prints, we award it the Overall *Best Performer* award for just laser printers.

The HP P1505 also wins the *Best Buy* award. It not only is one of the fastest printers in the category but also one of the cheapest. Feature-wise, it has a network port which is a big bonus for a printer and perfect for a small office scenario. The only complaint that one could have with the HP P1505 is the lack of double-sided printing. The P1505n was a slight different variant of the same HP P1505. The additional money you paid was for the 8 MB of cache on the device as well as the Ethernet con-

nectivity which allowed you to use the P1505n as a network device. For most home users, the network connectivity wouldn't be so useful. The price of the P1505 today is Rs 9,999 which might seem like quite a bit of money but for the kind of performance you get, it's worth it.

